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A Balanced Vision of God

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A Balanced Vision of God

“Notice therefore the kindness and severity of God.”

—Romans 11:22

To know God truly, we must know Him as He has revealed Himself—not as we prefer Him to be.

Dr. Bill Bright wrote:

“God has revealed His character to us in His Word so that we might know Him personally and walk with Him intimately. When we understand who God is—His love, His holiness, His power, His faithfulness—we are transformed. I am convinced that the greatest need of the church today is for believers to have a fresh vision of the greatness and glory of God. When we see God as He really is, our problems shrink and our faith grows.”

Notice the balance in that vision. Bright does not call us to see only God’s love, or only His holiness, or only His power. He names them together. A fresh vision of God is a whole vision of God.

Every believer is tempted to build a god from the attributes that feel safest. Some cling to love and quietly set holiness aside, until God becomes only warmth without moral fire. Some exalt holiness and forget love, until God becomes only judgment without mercy. Some emphasize sovereignty until prayer feels pointless. Some dwell on self-existence until God seems distant and uninvolved. In each case the distortion is the same: we are no longer beholding God. We are editing Him.

A partial view of God is not a smaller view of the same God. It is a different god.

Love without holiness is not the love of Scripture; it is sentiment.

Holiness without love is not the holiness of Scripture; it is severity.

Sovereignty without goodness is tyranny.

Goodness without sovereignty is a wish.

Self-existence without nearness is an abstraction.

Nearness without self-existence is an idol we can manage.

The God of the Bible is one God. His attributes are not competing parts we may rank according to taste. They are the undivided glory of who He is.

This is why the book is arranged in four groupings rather than a list of favorite qualities. Hold only one cluster and worship tilts. Hold them together and worship deepens. The God who needs nothing still gives Himself. The God who rules freely still binds Himself by promise. The God who is holy through and through still welcomes sinners in Christ. That is not contradiction. That is the true God.

The aim, then, is not to admire the attributes we already like. The aim is to let Scripture correct our vision until every attribute has its place, and none is used to cancel another. When love is read beside holiness, grace becomes costly and precious. When sovereignty is read beside love, providence becomes a refuge rather than a threat. When self-existence is read beside all the rest, we stop using God and start worshipping Him.

How the Four Remain Distinct

- **Self-Existence** reveals: Who is God apart from us?
- **Sovereignty** reveals: What can God do in relation to all things?
- **Holiness** reveals: What is God like in His moral nature?
- **Love** reveals: How does God give Himself to His creatures?

The uniqueness of each grouping is the question it answers. Together they form one portrait: the God who simply is, who reigns freely, who is pure through and through, and who gives Himself completely.

A Portrait of the One God

The chapters that follow are not four competing portraits. They are one God, beheld from every side. The seal below is the map of that vision.

At the center stands the simplest and most searching confession of Scripture: **God is**. Around that center is the foundation of His being—**self-existent**, our Independent God, who He is in Himself. From that foundation three movements go out toward the world: He is **sovereign**, our Sovereign Creator, in how He rules; He is **holy**, our Holy Judge, in how He makes right; He is **love**, our Loving Savior, in how He gives Himself. The outer ring holds all twenty attributes. None may be dropped. None may cancel another.

Hold only one cluster, and the circle tilts. Hold them together, and the seal is whole.

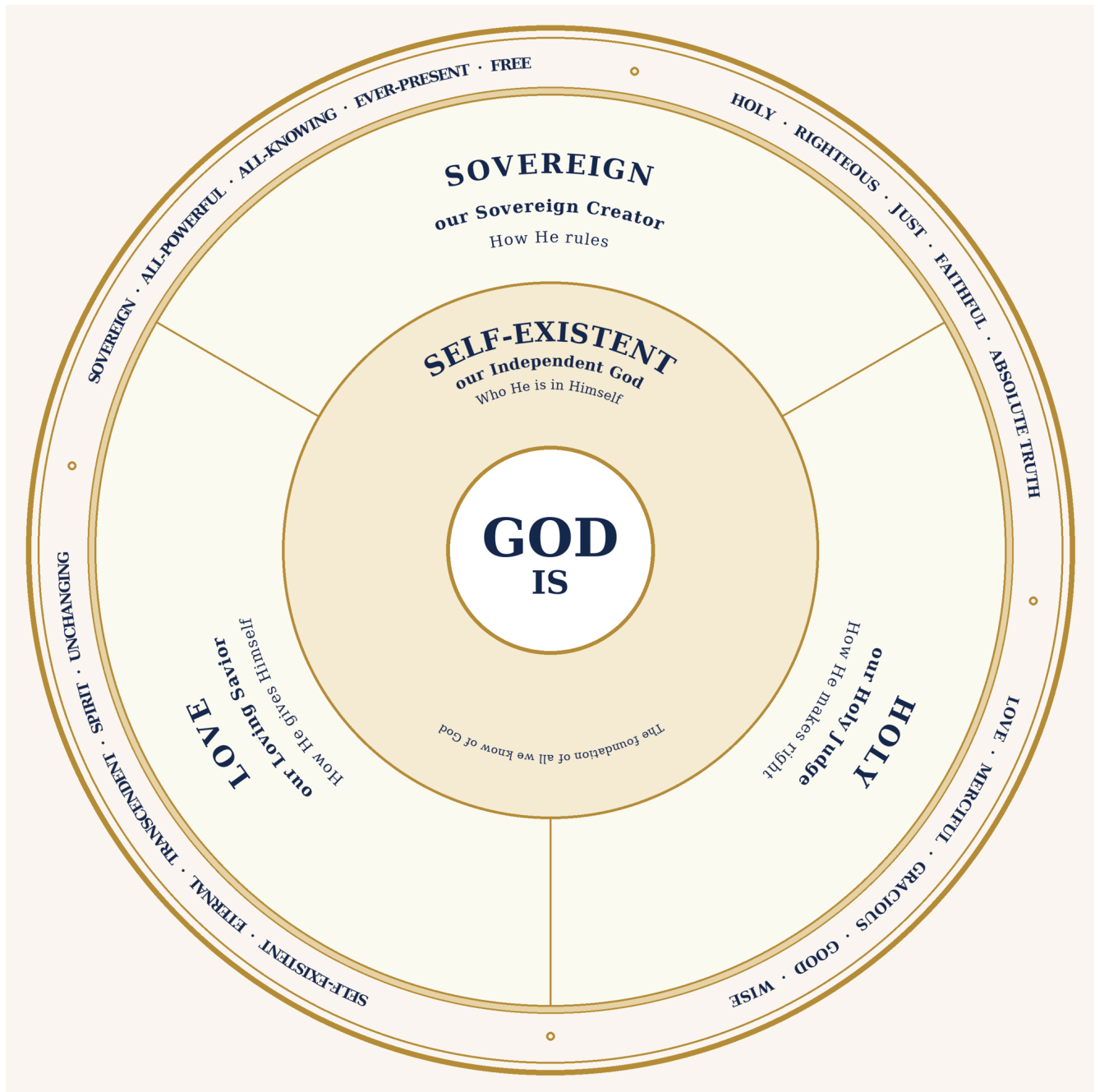


Figure. God is self-existent, sovereign, holy, and love.

Attributes of Self-Existence

- God Is Self-Existent
- God Is Eternal
- God Is Transcendent

- God Is Spirit
- God Is Unchanging

This grouping describes God in Himself, before any word is spoken about what He does for the world. These attributes would be true if nothing else existed. Self-existence is the fountainhead: God depends on nothing for His being. Eternality follows—He has no beginning or end. Transcendence follows—He is not a piece of the universe He made. Then He is Spirit follows—He is not bound by matter, form, or place. Then He is unchanging follows—He does not grow, diminish, or become, because He is already complete.

What sets this category apart is independence. The other three categories assume a God who relates to creation as King, as Holy One, and as the One who gives Himself. This category first establishes that He does not need creation in order to be God. He is the “I AM.” All rule, holiness, and love rest on this foundation.

Attributes of Sovereignty

- God Is Sovereign
- God Is All-Powerful (Omnipotent)
- God Is All-Knowing (Omniscient)
- God Is Present Everywhere (Omnipresent)
- God Is Free

This grouping describes God’s active relation to all He has made. These are not first truths about His inner sufficiency, but about His capacity to govern the world. Sovereignty is the heading: He rules. Omnipotence is the strength of that rule. Omniscience is the wisdom of that rule. Omnipresence is the reach of that rule. Freedom is the independence of that rule—He acts according to His own will and is not compelled by anything outside Himself.

What sets this category apart is ability exercised in authority. Holiness tells us His rule is pure. Love tells us His rule is good. Self-existence tells us His rule is not borrowed. Sovereignty tells us His rule is real. Nothing is outside His hand, His knowledge, His presence, or His free purpose.

Attributes of Holiness

- God Is Holy
- God Is Righteous
- God Is Just
- God Is Faithful
- God Is Absolute Truth

This grouping describes God's moral perfection—His separation from all sin and His unwavering commitment to what is right. Holiness is the radiant center: God is utterly set apart. Righteousness is holiness in His ways. Justice is holiness in His judgments. Faithfulness is holiness in His commitments. Absolute truth is holiness in His speech and standard. He cannot lie, cannot break covenant, and cannot call evil good.

What sets this category apart is integrity of character. Sovereignty without holiness would be raw power. Love without holiness would be sentiment. Self-existence without holiness would be mere force. Holiness tells us that the independent, reigning God is light, and in Him there is no darkness at all. This is why worship begins with awe, and why the gospel must include the cross: the Holy One does not ignore sin.

Attributes of Love

- God Is Love
- God Is Merciful
- God Is Gracious
- God Is Good
- God Is Wise

This grouping describes God's self-giving heart—not only that He is able and pure, but that He moves toward His creatures for their good. Love is the essence-word of the group: "God is love." Mercy is love toward the guilty and miserable, withholding what we deserve. Grace is love toward the undeserving, giving what we could never earn. Goodness is love delighting to bless. Wisdom is love choosing the right ends and the right means for those He loves.

What sets this category apart is self-giving movement. Self-existence could stand alone in blessedness. Sovereignty could rule in silence. Holiness could remain a consuming fire. Love is the God who gives Himself. The other categories keep love from becoming softness: the One who loves is also independent, sovereign, and holy. This category keeps the others from becoming distant: the Holy King who needs nothing still seeks us in Christ.

If what comes into our minds when we think about God is shaped by preference, our faith will be fragile, our obedience selective, and our comfort thin. If that thought is shaped by the whole counsel of God, our problems shrink, our reverence grows, and our trust rests on the God who actually is:

the One who simply is,
who reigns freely,
who is pure through and through,
and who gives Himself completely.

With that vision before us, we turn first to the Attributes of Self-Existence.

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In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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